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Helen Oakley Dance

Helen Oakley Dance has been involved in jazz since the 1930s. Born in Toronto in 1913, she moved to Chicago as a young woman to be closer to the hot jazz of the decade. Through her own initiative, she recorded Paul Mares, Jabbo Smith and Jess Stacey, and staged concerts with Count Basie and Benny Goodman. It was at one of these concerts that Benny was brought together with pianist Teddy Wilson, setting the stage for one of the most famous trios in jazz history. Helen enjoyed a long and fruitful relationship with Duke Ellington and produced numerous small group recordings with Duke and members of his orchestra for the Variety label. She has written for Down Beat, The Saturday Review *and* The Music Journal*, and in 1987 she authored* Stormy Monday, The T-Bone Walker Story*. Helen married Stanley Dance in 1947. Together they have become a part of jazz history by documenting priceless stories from the Golden Age of Jazz.*

Helen and Stanley currently reside in Vista, California. Helen was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 12, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in San Diego filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I am honored to have Helen Oakley Dance as my guest, author and jazz lover. Thanks so much for being with me.

HD: "Jazz producer" is what I like best.

MR: Jazz producer.

HD: That's what I think is most important — the music that you have contrived to bring out. Don't you think so?

MR: Yeah.

HD: That's what it is.

MR: When you use "contrive," how does that work as a producer?

HD: I don't even think of it that way. I mean you know I started very early. I think I was the first, I was the first woman producer, and I was in Chicago before *DownBeat* was born really, and so you know I was also the first contributor. But I just always looked on it from the start 'til now as you are just a channel. I don't think of producing it, I think of it being produced through you. And that's what I think is very important, because that's what is important. And of course you can be helpful, but the main thing is that you are a channel I think.

MR: Do you think a producer can try to put their mark on music too much?

HD: Yes. I think there's not sufficient respect all the time for the musicians — the gift that's there that you're trying to retain for history. Don't you?

MR: Yes. Can you recall when you first heard jazz music and were attracted to it?

HD: Well of course I know Stanley is probably going to wish to argue about this, but I always insist I was in Toronto, which was very corny then, not quite so corny now, but there was jazz, it existed, it wasn't an elephant, and in those days the family had records in batches once a month, from the big record stores you see, and so about twelve records, which everybody had a chance to approve. And only I would catch on to one, which nobody else liked, and of course it was jazz. And I was eight years old. Stanley wants to argue about that. But to me I was eight years old, I was a child.

MR: Well he wasn't there, was he?

HD: You know it was my first thing — the first time that I ever said this is who I am. And mother would say, "Well Helen can have her records," which was always it. And it was Coal Cart Blues by — let's see my memory fails me all the time — Stanley might be able to mutter things in the background, could he?

MR: Yes. It wasn't the Original Dixieland Jazz Band was it?

HD: Oh no, no, no. It was black. It was —

MR: Coal Cart Blues.

HD: It was very, very early. The early, early blues. The first records that I listened to. It was black records. Who was it?

[inaudible off stage comment]

No, it was a band. It wasn't even Bechet, it was before that.

MR: King Oliver?

HD: Yeah, it was back in his days, definitely. And so that was when I was first introduced to jazz. And right away, that was it. And that's all I wanted to know about, and hear. And I didn't know what the instruments were or what I was listening to, but I always knew what I was listening to. And years later I said oh that's Benny Goodman. And then I'd say oh that's Bunny Berrigan. I knew all those instruments but I didn't know what they were. I wasn't a trained musician. But happily I think I might say, like many musicians, I did have ears. And that's what's important.

MR: And eventually you were able to tell one player from another.

HD: That's right. And one instrument from another was very important.

MR: So the music in Toronto, when you were growing up, was the typical pop music of the times?

HD: To me there wasn't any.

MR: There wasn't any.

HD: Luigi Romanelli was like the Lombardos.

MR: Oh, okay.

HD: And then, but I had an older brother that Duke was also very fond of. And he and I would listen and go to things together. And so that way, he and his friends who were going on to

college, they trained me you know, and they were beginning to play something. And they'd say, "Well that's a clarinet you know." And I would tell them, "That's what's good."

MR: And when was the first time you got to see and hear jazz — to see something live?

HD: You must stop me you know, if you want me to move from period to period — but because I would not do the things — my sister and I were close in age and we were debutantes in Toronto and that was Toronto for you. And she went on from there and had quite a wonderful career. And I said no, I'm going to the States. And my family didn't think much of that. And so my mother said, "All right, I'll take you to Detroit, and I'll see that you're set up properly, have a piano and somebody to watch over you" and so on. So I was in Detroit. So I said, "Okay, the Graystone Ballroom for me." And it was Fletcher Henderson. And you know it was way back in '33 wouldn't it be? Something like that. Stanley will correct me if I'm wrong. But anyway so for my long dream, for our deb party, I had wanted to have McKinney's Cotton Pickers, because of Fats, who sang "Baby Won't You Please Come Home," and those wonderful things. And Fats died on the way up to Toronto. And so we never did get them. But Fletcher Henderson was a very good substitute as far as I was concerned, because I thought, at last Hawk. And so I arrived all alone, at the Graystone Ballroom in the black section of Detroit, and, all big guys, and making my way into the front of the bandstand, which is where I remained for the rest of my career. And there was Fletcher's band, and where was Hawk? He'd just gone to England. And it was Lester. Well but you see I didn't have enough ears, because I was listening for Hawk, and like the rest of the band, we all thought that Lester wasn't making it, including Ms. Lee, Fletcher's wife, who told him — you know Lester always tells, "Took him down in the basement" and said, "now listen to this, this is how you're supposed to sound," and you know enough to know what Prez was like, you know, such a gentle soul. He wouldn't say to you you were all wrong or you aren't with this or anything. But he soon quit the band. He wasn't fired. They didn't think he was doing a great job because he didn't take Hawk's place. But Lester knew, he went back to Basie. He went back to Kansas City. So well that was my first experience. And after that I quickly thought Detroit's nowhere, and I must go to Chicago. And I was very lucky there, because I don't know whether you know or not, did you ever hear of a man called Squirrel Ashcraft?

MR: Yes.

HD: Well Stanley and I have our archives together at Yale. And I insisted in having a mini-archive on Squirrel. Because although Stanley and I are supposed to be entirely black, we're not entirely black, and in those days, in Chicago, there was Davy Tough, there was

Bud [Freeman], there was — well I didn't know Teschemacher — but I mean it was a wonderful school.

MR: Jimmy McPartland was there?

HD: Yeah. It was a wonderful school. I mean I still get things like that and Stanley's face doesn't light up like mine does, but that was my background, all white jazz. And I consider it was — I don't know where there were backgrounds for white jazz. The people that liked Bix, they were, and Squirrel Ashcraft was a very close friend of Bix's. And you know the bass saxophone, Rollini, and people. That was the white thing coming up. And it really was very important. Because those were white guys who were moved. And they were in Chicago and they'd go down to the south side all the time you see and they'd go to DeLisa and so on. And of course they were listening to Louis and — who did Louis come after?

MR: King Oliver.

HD: And King Oliver and everything in those days. So it was a wonderful start for me. You know I was able to get both sides.

MR: Yes. Right in the middle of it.

HD: It was terrific. And then so that's when I started recording, which I don't know whether you're interested in.

MR: Absolutely. I wanted to ask you about Chicago. So this is early '30s? Mid-30s?

HD: Mid. I left Chicago in '36. And probably I started with Duke in Detroit at the Fox Theater. And I was 18 and from Toronto. And of course Duke was Duke. And I was darned if I wasn't going to go backstage. I didn't know what backstage was all about, but I was going to go. So I did. And you know Duke had a marvelous sense of humor, and a marvelous feeling for life, so I knew it would be fun, interesting. And so when this gal appeared, you know, and sent up her — I sent him a letter on English note paper. Stanley and I had both, separately, without knowing one another, we'd both heard those wonderful concerts in London. And so I sent a letter, supposedly signed by Spike Hughes, who was a favorite of his, saying that this girl has probably got something to offer you. Receive her. And this just played into Duke's hands. He had me ushered up. Mill was his girl from a long time. So I went in the dressing room, and Duke received me in a most marvelous fashion, and of course I was honored. And I had the brass to tell him what I thought was the best in his work, and how I didn't really appreciate Barney Bigard. And of course he loves Barney. Because I liked the other type, I liked the New Orleans more than Barney. Barney was typical of New Orleans, but anyway, so he listened to me with the greatest kindness. And I said, "Would you honor us by coming and having afternoon tea one day this week?" And he said yes. And they had afternoon tea, and I saw my letter up on the mirror, and I knew it shouldn't be there. Why was my

letter on the mirror? With all the fans he'd had, why was mine up there? And I looked at him and we looked at each other and I said, "I probably shouldn't have forged it, should I?" And he said, "Oh I'm so pleased you did." So we were friends forever after you know. That was wonderful. So he took me downstairs and said to the guys, "This is family, guys, lay off." And it was wonderful, because I was family, and for the rest of my life, and for as long as he lived, I was family, and that was the greatest thing that ever happened to me.

MR: That's a wonderful story.

HD: Yeah. It's a wonderful thing. So I went to Chicago, and I wanted to record the guys, Jess for instance. I'd never recorded before. Nobody knew about Jess. Stacy, you know. And Jess and George Wettling, and Paul Mares. And so I wanted to record them. They were at the — gee I don't know the title of the place, it was a famous place, a New Orleans spot, where they played. And so I did that. I think it was The Brunswick. But actually the Brunswick studios were kaput after a while, because the elevated ran right there.

MR: Oh, the trains.

HD: The train. They had a terrible run, it was bad on the thing, but they were good records they're still here. Boyce Brown was the one — I want to tell you something about Boyce afterwards. He was an alto player, you probably never heard of him. But he was the first. He was a white boy and he was blind, and very soulful, and he played wonderful alto, long before you heard about Benny Carter. If you hear those records you will see that he had a natural gift and it was wonderful. He joined a monastery in the end and he died, but he was probably the best musician out there, and he was quite wonderful. So eventually I went from there to recording a big band, Lavier Johnson, he called himself Charles Lavier afterwards, pianist. And we did a big band. Jabbo came in and was in the band, and Scorsoothy, and all those musicians that I'm talking about, Jess and so on. And it was a pretty good session. Stanley can tell you about it. It's still — it's been re-issued time and again.

MR: Let me ask you, you said you wanted to record these people. Well how do you get from wanting to do it, to actually—

HD: I don't really know. I just did. I went up in the studios and set up a time.

MR: You paid for it yourself?

HD: No, no. No, no. I sold them a bill of goods. And I was a so-called writer so I was on the Chicago Herald Trib too, and so I said to them, "You might as well let me do the social column, because I know all these guys like Squirrel Ashcraft and all these prominent people. And that's how I got Lawrence — Benny Goodman in the trio, because, you've heard about Benny, what a funny guy he was. And I was a friend of Freddy Goodman's, who was a trumpet player manque. You know he was a wonderful musician and he didn't

really have a lip which was very unfortunate. He had all the talent and he knew everything, but he couldn't really cut it as a trumpet player. But anyway, we were great friends, and I said to him well Benny's coming. And I said to Stanley the other day I wrote one fan letter in my life, and that was to Benny. And I recently wrote another one to Sir Alec Guinness. Did you read *My Name Escapes Me*?

MR: No.

HD: Well you should. You'll love it. So anyway, I'd never written a thing and Benny had never had one. So when he came he was interested and I said to the people at the Urban Room at the show in Chicago — I forgot the name of the hotel. But anyway I said to them well now listen, Benny Goodman's coming, and he's flopped all the way across the nation, until he got to The Palomar in L.A. And there they'd heard him, because they heard the late broadcasts. And I said, "It's terribly important, that when he gets to Chicago he's got to be a success, otherwise they'll think that's the only thing he has. So I got Squirrel Ashcraft and all these — and we formed the Chicago Rhythm Club. And I said all right, now we've got to get ready for Goodman to come, and we've got to make a success of it. And we'll have concerts. Because in England, they'd introduced concerts.

MR: Jazz concerts.

HD: It was a concert that Stanley and I had heard. Except the thing was not known in the U.S. you know. And so I went up to talk to Benny, and he'd had a very hard head you know, and only money talked to Benny. And so he listened you know, and he pulled a long face. And I said, "We're going to put on a concert on Sunday with you." And he's thinking you know, what's the money. And I said, "It's a benefit for the union, and the union has agreed." And so well he couldn't really argue about that. So it was all set. And so what we did was, we gave a concert with the band, all these debbies were out selling all the tickets and it was absolutely sold out. And of course and *Time* magazine put it on the cover. This was a first. A concert of jazz, and these people. And so the follow-up on that was important, because I said to Benny, I want Teddy. And he said, "Who's going to do it?" And I said, "You." We'll pay the fare to bring him. Well then I talked to Teddy and his wife Irene Wilson, you know, who wrote "Some Other Spring" and those things. She was a wonderful pianist, a woman pianist in Chicago in the early, early days. And so we brought Teddy, and we said well what we'll do, Irving Kauffman was in charge of the house, and I said well what we'll do is, there's no dancing, it's a concert. There's no dance floor. So we'll clear a little bit of the floor and we'll bring Gene Krupa and Benny and Teddy down and the piano. And we'll put on the trio. And that was the first time that inter-racial anything was ever given in public. And it was the Benny Goodman Trio. And so from there on of course Teddy stayed with the band and it all happened. So that was good.

MR: That is — I didn't know that that had happened like that.

HD: Well there's a lot of people — John Hammond used to say that he did it. And we were good friends.

MR: Now Teddy Wilson was a name in Chicago and New York?

HD: Well he wasn't a name in Chicago really. He was there. And Irene, who was a name, she helped him. Earl was his idol and everything, but he ended up in New York, and I think he was in — I've forgotten the band he was in — but anyway, Benny Carter had already said watch it, you know, because this boy can really play. And so he really didn't have a name at that point. His name began with that trio.

MR: How much — did they have any rehearsal time before this happened?

HD: No, no. They never really used to have. And the other thing I wanted to tell you about that series was that the next thing was Duke. See by then I was practically traveling with the Ellington band every now and then. When I wasn't there for the stage thing, I was fined if I was late. And so Duke was the next thing, and that of course was wonderful. That's when he first played "Reminiscing in Tempo." Shall I tell a naughty story about John?

MR: Mr. Hammond?

HD: Yes, Mr. Hammond.

MR: I think we could.

HD: Well it was not really naughty. We'd become friends by that time. But John you know prided himself on everything, and was critical of Duke quite often. So then, and he had an ugly word or so to say about "Reminiscing in Tempo," which Duke had written because his mother had died, and he was very serious at that time. And then John came out and heard the band and said, "What is that wonderful number?" We said, "John, we're not going to let you forget that one." And after that it was Fletcher Henderson who was playing in Earl's spot. And so Fletcher came, and he had Roy and Chu in the band.

MR: Roy Eldridge and Chu Berry.

HD: Yes. And that was wonderful. So that really was how I ended up my Chicago thing. But it was Duke who spoke up and said to Irving Mills, "Now then, you've got to bring this girl into New York." Why? Well I'm just telling you. Because that's how Duke operated. He always spotted, even if you had a minimum amount of talent, he'd find it for you.

MR: Make the most of it.

HD: Exactly. The fact that Duke said it, that was enough you know. And so Irving Mills — I was brought into Mills' office and that was the other half of my career, because as Stanley I think told you, Mills started these two record companies, Master Records was the top label, and Variety was the second. And I was the producer. I used to sit at this long table with about twenty accountants and people, and then they said to me, what have

you to say? And I said, and so somebody said, "She did those Goodman things, and she did this and she did that you see. And so I said, "We ought to make the small band records." And I knew Duke would agree you see, because Duke, amongst other things, he had a very good head for what could make a bit of money. Because he needed to. How was he going to keep going if he didn't? And so of course that was a very good idea, because for two years, well it went on after I left them, we just made the small bands. You know the small bands, don't you? Well you know, so it was Cootie and Johnny that I wanted of course. And so Duke started off with Barney [Bigard] and with Lawrence [Brown] I think, and — yes Stanley's saying something. Ray Nance? Rex, of course, who never really was able to show who he really was or how. You know he had a bit of a complex. I think his writing later shows you really who he is. But anyway, he was a wonderful musician. I mean with Fletcher Henderson, people knew that. He didn't show up, to my mind, for what he really was. Duke established a personality for him and made him stay in it you know. Man with a horn, boy with a horn, and those things. But anyway that was great, great fun for a couple of years we made those small— No, we never rehearsed, we never did anything.

MR: Was there competition among Duke's men to want to be a part of these records?

HD: No. I mean Duke's men, you know, is another story as I know you must know. It was a complicated family, with all the family stories that are in families. There were ins and outs and they changed sometimes and so on. No, nobody ever, you never saw the face of people you know. As you know, Johnny Hodges had a complete, immovable face, no matter what gorgeous thing he was playing. And so they had little things. I mean Johnny and Barney had, they sat next to one another. They had a little something at times. But mostly everything, it was the Ellington band, and as a family, nobody else knew. It was family affairs. And they quietly carried on their family affairs. It was very, very interesting.

MR: What was a good number of records to sell at that time?

HD: That they sold?

MR: Yeah.

HD: That they sold. Well let's say better what were the big things in the stage shows. Because you know at the stage shows the screen would come on and the medley would come on, you couldn't help it. It had to be, you know, because that's what the public knew. And so you had "Sophisticated Lady," and you had all the things. And when you'd get rid of the medley, then you'd see what Ellington was going to give you, you know. He changed that quite a bit. And of course then he would have to have a vocalist. But of course he had Ivy then. And he loved Ivy. Ivy to me was not the singer that Billie was or one or two people. But she was a stylist, and she could fit right in there, what Duke wanted. And she'd do

those things, and Rex would play those things in the background you know, "Rug Cutter" and those things, and well no, Sonny did those funny things with Ivy, but Rex too, on the horn. And so I don't know whether I've answered your question properly.

MR: Well I was thinking you had mentioned sitting at a long table with the accountants. And if you released a series of records, did they then, months later, say to you look those particular records are not selling well, or they are selling well? Did you have to justify—

HD: They didn't have to tell me. I knew what was happening.

MR: What's the number of records at that time which would have meant a good release?

HD: Well you see there were two labels. Duke's things were really the band, was on the Master label. So then they had to make the money. They had to do "Sophisticated Lady" and all the things that would make the money. And they did. And my things, I was much better off, because my label was the thirty-five cent label, and it was the jazz label, and of course I think really those small band records have proven themselves over the years. Because they are still thought wonderful by the musicians. Mostly all musicians today will recognize what was offered there. And of course it was marvelous because they were not rehearsed. And there was Duke on the piano. I mean the music came out of them. You know Duke would sit there on the piano and he'd just hammer away a minute or two and he'd look over and say, "Rab, come up with something." Rabbitt. And so Johnny would not look pleased of course, because if he looked pleased he wouldn't be able to ask for money afterwards you see. So it was always going to be difficult. And so then he'd play eight bars maybe. Not more. Not sixteen. Eight. And Cootie, and they were good friends, as Duke would say "Coot," and Cootie would oblige with eight bars. There you had your number right there. So then Duke would just play the chords for the middle, for the release you know. They were wonderful. They made the number, and then he came back. And there was your number. And of course you only had three minutes, and it depended on the tempo whether you had two choruses or what. And then Irving would be there in the control room, making trouble. I very often was in the control room, but most of the time I'd be in there with the band. They'd say you know, if she's smiling, that's it, it's okay. And so then he'd bring these "foodgie woodgies," these poor little dears, these little blonde things that would sing the pretty songs, which Irving would insist were being played, because he was a song plugger. Irving made his way as a song plugger you know. So that made it a little difficult you know. But then I did have one story that has been quoted, because it bothered me, this business of these — the time wasted on these vocal numbers, and it was all precious time. And so after the date was over you know I said to Johnny and Cootie I guess and Harry, and I said, "Well I'm sorry guys," you know, "you couldn't help." And Johnny said, "I thought she was very cute." So I said, "How can you win?" So anyway, that's that period.

MR: Oh that's a marvelous story. And when Ellington would just sit and play those chords, was that, do you think that was fairly spontaneous?

HD: Oh absolutely spontaneous. I mean it was the Duke. All he had to do, it makes me think of Monk when I was going to say aren't you lucky to be called Monk. I mean you'd make sounds and it talks, like it did with Monk too. And so those sounds were Duke's inspiration. And almost any sound, Stanley traveled with him in, I don't know about the Far East, but a great deal. And there he heard sounds, and his music came out of that.

MR: Yes. He talked about that in the books I've read, in that he didn't try to mimic them specifically, but it was more of an ambiance or —

HD: Inspired. So was Monk. Same thing. And anyway, after that well there was a period there, in years perhaps, that completed my career because then I went into the Office of Strategic Services, which was America's spy unit, you know, and we went abroad, and we sent bodies in France and things like that you know. So that followed and that ended that period of mine. But at that time it was nice, because I worked with Mildred [Bailey] and Red [Norvo] a certain amount, but various people. The Crosby band, I'm the one that said to Gil Roden, form a small band out of those guys, those wonderful guys, Eddie Miller and those guys, because Ray [Baduc] was a good drummer and so on. And they did. And I had a card from Bob Haggart this Christmas, which quoted a little paragraph saying, "Bring on the Bobcats and we'll go into the back hall" and so on. But it made me laugh. But I left Mills because I didn't have a free enough hand, and of course my things weren't making a lot of money, but Johnny's "Jeep's Blues" and those things, they were heard from one end of Harlem to the other end. Juke boxes on every block. And of course it was hugely popular you know. The small bands were very popular. And there was one guy left that had a tremendous amount of talent and never really made it and that was Chick Webb. And he was a wonderful little guy, with tremendous ears. The guys in the band used to say no matter who hit what note, and he couldn't lead, but he always look around and gave the guy a — stared at the guy. Am I running out of time?

MR: No, no.

HD: Well anyway, so that office hired me to make a hit with Chick. And Chick, who'd had a wonderful band all those years, and with like Cootie and Johnny, lived in an apartment with Chick, they were all hungry. And they'd had offers but they wouldn't leave Chick. Johnny was supposed to be Chick's cousin which he wasn't. But they were very close. And Chick had this wonderful background, and it never happened. And you see he had TB. He had TB. People didn't know, but they knew he wasn't well. And he was the bravest little guy and the most wonderful character you could possibly imagine. A big talker and a big time guy. And you'd go uptown into the corner of 137th and 7th Avenue or wherever, and you'd see a group of musicians, a circle of musicians, spellbound. You

wondered why, because you couldn't see who was in the middle. It was Chick. And he'd get people by their lapel and tell them things. Everybody loved him. And Stanley and I had a very marvelous experience because when Stanley came over we went up you know, and he called me "Oakley," Chick. He'd say, "Oakley, this kid" — Stanley blamed me for this story — but he told me, "Oakley, this kid's in love wich you." Wich you. And of course naturally Stanley didn't expect to be taken seriously, and he wasn't. But anyway we had fun. And so I built Chick up. But I was in a horrible office you know, money guys, who didn't care, and so I wanted to make a name for them. And so and of course Benny I knew well. So I said to them, "Well put on a battle of Swing." In England they had battles of Swing, and we'll put one on. We've never had one in America. So we put on a battle of Swing, and so I told Benny, and so Benny was not going to care. And he was a decent guy, Benny, basically. And I mean he was a musician and he loved music, so he respected it. So he played the famous concert and from there we all went up to the Savoy Ballroom. And the two bands battled. And the mounted police was out, there were thousands of people all over the streets and you couldn't get in. And it was wonderful. And I didn't want to ruin Chick. And of course I knew that Gene Krupa just worshipped Chick anyway. And so actually it wasn't too horrible an affair, because although Benny was a tremendous success, the Savoy Ballroom belonged to Chick, the place was Chick Webb's place. And then there was Ella. So Ella came on and that turned the tide of course. So it was considered you know, okay.

MR: Was it a tie?

HD: I think I wrote it up in *Down Beat* and I said it was a tie, and I was afraid that the musicians there would doubt it. But it went over as a tie you know. And after that, so that went very well, and built Chick, and he went into the Paramount Hotel and so on and so on. He was desperately ill all the time, but he used to faint after. He played five shows at the Paramount a day, and he would faint. He was — loss of blood and everything. But he was so game. So after that, you know, we said what's next. And I don't think they were too happy, but Basie came to town. And I'd been listening to Basie and Basie, they were very kind, Basie and Prez, and Bas' said, "This gal is the gal that's writing in *Down Beat*." And Irving said to me, "I'll let you give a party. I've got their recordings use. Ask everybody you want." So as to everybody I could think of that meant something, that could play, and the New York Rhythm Club came in on it too, Milt Gabler and so on, and the Basie band came in. They didn't play. Earl played and I'm not sure that Earl played, he was there. But anyway.

MR: Are you talking about Earle Warren?

HD: No Earl Hines. There's only one Earl. But anyway it was a great success, it was wonderful. And so I knew that I really fell in love with the Basie band, because that was THE band, and THE rhythm section, and Lester. And of course the brass.

MR: Let me ask you something. I got to meet Claude "Fiddler" Williams. And apparently when Basie first came to New York, Claude was in the guitar chair.

HD: Was he? I didn't know about that.

MR: But it didn't last.

HD: No it couldn't. No. Especially with Freddie, because he was so wonderful.

MR: That sound of that — I mean I'm convinced in my own mind that the sound of that acoustic instrument just chomping —

HD: Me too. I still think that. Do you still think that?

MR: Yeah. I mean it just added that extra bit to the rhythm section.

HD: It added a bit of something musical. You know, the chords, and the strings. I was thinking just the other day, Stanley was playing something very good, and I thought, what a pity they were so smart as to mix out the guitar. Because it was a wonderful rhythm instrument. And of course the guys used to say you know, Freddie wouldn't let you — not Jo Jones, he was wonderful. But they used to say Freddie wouldn't let you budge from the beat. Freddie was immovable from the beat, which was really quite wonderful. But anyway I'm sure we're running out of time.

MR: No we're not.

HD: Oh good. Well I'll just tell you end of that then, because the end was I knew I was fighting a losing battle. Well then I put on a battle of the bands between Chick and Basie. And you knew that there was only one answer there. Although Chick, he was a battler. And of course the sound of his drums, there was nothing like it. And that bass, that boom boom, that started up, the whole Savoy Ballroom used to, lift the floor. And so Chick held his own as far as the people were concerned. But there was really no comparison. And Billie wasn't with the band, she'd left the band then, but anyway it was the Basie band. So after it was all over the Webb band called a meeting and said, "She set us up — she exposed us" you know, "she set us up." And I didn't care for the band anyway, and it wasn't a wonderful band, and naturally they didn't like me. And you know so, and Chick, by that time he was pretty ill, and he was frankly upset. And I said to him, you know, "Chick, if the office wants to fire me, let them. I've done my job, I've put you where you're supposed to be and that's what they hired me for." And so that's the end of that. And it really was, after that, I pretty well lost interest, and the thing was that he went to Baltimore and it broke my heart because he felt that he wanted me with him. And I should have been with him. And if he didn't have a bad office I would have been with him whether, no matter, anything. And I used to worry and worry about him, and he was

progressively dying. And so in Baltimore he went and played another thing on board ship, and we were in white, Baltimore, and he was making signals to me to get over and to speak and everything and I didn't. Because I didn't want to get him in trouble either. I mean I could have also been in trouble, and I didn't want to get him in trouble, so I didn't. And it broke my heart because he was giving me that eye, that desperate eye, and I didn't. And he went straight into Johns Hopkins and died five days later. And that was quite a heartbreaker. So after that I was approached by the OSS, and I thought — Rupert had died, that wonderful brother that Duke had loved too, and he died at Dieppe, you know the invasion of Dieppe. And I guess my heart had sort of gone out of things. So from my point of view, and probably yours, my career in jazz ended. I did do what I could for T-Bone, which was wonderful, but none of it compared with those.

MR: I want to ask you a couple of things about those times. Chicago in the 30s, when you first started doing those records there, how was the depression and prohibition part of the whole atmosphere.

HD: It's funny, I always thought to myself that I was there in the worst time and I never really realized it. It's probably because I wasn't there before it. And it was hard. And of course it was hard. I took it for granted that it would be hard. Jazz was playing in The Subway, which opened at ten at night and closed at four AM, and nobody cared for them or listened to them or paid any attention. And it was like that then. And all the guys were playing in dance halls, and nobody paid any attention. You know, Muggsy [Spanier] — I didn't really know Muggsy, I wish I'd known him better — but there was wonderful music. And I think everybody just took it for granted that these were rough and tough. And it wasn't until I came to New York and — who introduced, who broke it, the depression — not Lyndon Johnson, but before him —

MR: Roosevelt.

HD: Roosevelt, who became the modern Commander In Chief, and it began to lighten you see because he sensibly started that whatever he called it—The New Deal. And that helped the guys. That helped bolster the guys too. And it introduced a breath of fresh air. And so Chicago was down, although the south side was always romping, always. Later Stanley and I, I think we took Earl there, I know I went with somebody, and it was still the Club DeLisa, and I mean it was still wild. In the early days of course it was Louis — and who did Louis—

MR: King Oliver.

HD: And King Oliver, and there was Earl who was absolutely marvelous, and so that Chicago was a mixture. It was terrific musically, even for the poor white guys who weren't making it. But the depression was there, yeah.

MR: The other question I had was regarding these battle of the bands. Logistically, like in the Savoy, what would they do? One band would play for half an hour, or a set —

HD: A set.

MR: —and the people would respond?

HD: Well the two bands were side by side you see. And it was a huge floor and it was a mass of human beings. And as I said, the police, the mounted police outside, trying to keep order because it was tremendous. But Chick did own that audience. The minute he'd go boom boom, everybody would scream because he was king. And so they wouldn't move from bandstand to bandstand, because there wasn't room. But you'd be listening to one thing or the other you see. And that's how it was.

MR: Was it a totally black audience at that time?

HD: No, no. The usual audience was totally black. But then all of those downtown that were terribly interested in the music, they'd come up you see. So the white people who were there were there for a purpose. So but otherwise it was. And it had one funny function. You know in the black world, there are levels, just as there are in the bands. And there were sophisticated society groups that met and had their balls. And a certain night of the week, the so-and-so ball would be there. And maybe they'd have their own band there. Or if they didn't then you had to play waltzes, and behave you know. But that was the Savoy for you. Sad that it ended.

MR: What a time, huh?

HD: Yes, it was a wonderful time.

[inaudible off stage comment]

HD: I don't know. You know I didn't know that. I guess, since I couldn't cook I wasn't up there.

MR: And the Savoy shut down about when?

HD: Well I wasn't there when it shut down. When I came back it was gone.

MR: Now you met Stanley at first in '37 was it?

HD: '36 when I was recording and he came to the sessions. '37. I knew he'd correct me on the dates because I never —

MR: So you had a ten year romance?

HD: Yes, really.

MR: I mean you've had a lifelong romance, let me rephrase that.

HD: I must tell a story about my mother. Because Stanley very bravely and wonderfully, well as Webb said, "Okay that boy's in love wich you." And so Stan made a trip over after the war you see? We'd been writing once a year for ten years. That's all we'd do. But my family and his family, who were lovely, they were terribly good to mine. My brother, who died over there, he was his best man when he was married and they were great

518 friends, and my sister, who did die later, was a Captain in the Canadian Army, and was
519 the first woman to step into Rome after it fell. She was quite a wonderful person. And so
520 I joined the U.S. Army and my mother said to me, "I don't understand you" she said,
521 "What about the British lion?" I said, "Well there's always the American eagle." She
522 didn't like it. The British lion you see, if you were in the Canadian Army. But anyway, so
523 when Stanley came over, she telephoned one night from Toronto and said, "Well, what's
524 it all about? I mean what's it going to come to?" And that's when I knew I would marry
525 Stanley because she said to Stanley, "What's the story?" And Stanley said, "Well, she
526 only loves me on Tuesdays and Thursdays." And I thought I certainly will marry that
527 man. And so we went up to Toronto and everything was very wonderful you see.
528 MR: Did you get married on a Tuesday or a Thursday?
529 HD: Did we. But he took me to England and it was lovely you know. And we had our 51st
530 wedding anniversary this year.
531 MR: Congratulations. That's great. I have a couple of more minutes, and then we'll wrap up. I
532 did want to mention the T-Bone Walker book. I think it must have been a great deal of
533 work.
534 HD: Well it was all a pleasure. T-Bone was another personality like Chick. He was a
535 wonderful person, and of course he was a wonderful guitarist, and a wonderful singer.
536 And Stanley and I, Stanley had a friend who sent him records and we first heard him
537 when we were there. And I've always loved blues anyways. And so I said to T-Bone in
538 New York, I said, "I'm going to write a book about you." He never heard of such a thing.
539 And so his wife, who's still alive and very nice and very sweet, and I said well I'll come
540 out to L.A. And Stanley said okay. He didn't think much of it but he said okay. And so I
541 went out three different times, twice to be with T-Bone and Joe Turner and Eddie
542 Cleanhead. Those guys. Because they were a whole group and they were really quite
543 wonderful as I think you might see from that book. And the third time I went out for the
544 memorial concert, which I helped to organize and which was sad. And I'm still in touch
545 with them always.
546 MR: Tim, why don't you flip that, and then I'll just wrap this up.
547 MR: You know it was almost like a novel, and I knew the ending, but I wanted to say to T-
548 Bone like don't take that drink, you know, don't— you wanted to — such a life, such a
549 blues life.
550 HD: I'm so glad that you liked him, because Stanley will contradict me, but the fact was that
551 Stanley didn't like it. I hadn't done a book before, I'd done writing you know. And so
552 Stanley helped me, you know, he would criticize. Criticize is the word, always, isn't he a
553 critic? And so it was different from anything that he's critiqued. And I knew he didn't
554 think too much of it. And so I wasn't too sure myself. But the people in Louisiana, the

press, were very nice. And they loved it. And a reader, she said, "I'm writing you this letter because it moved me." The reader said, "I've never read anything that moved me so much, and I cried both times I read it."

MR: Both times.

HD: And I thought well, and so I said to Stanley you see, there is something there that somebody liked, and you evidently liked it, Monk.

MR: I did.

HD: You loved him. He came across, didn't he?

MR: Yeah. And it makes me want to go back and listen to his music more, especially when you hear the other guitarists talk about him too you know.

HD: Yeah, he's a wonderful person.

MR: Well this has really been fascinating.

HD: It's interesting to talk with you. And I think it's wonderful what you're doing, doing this archive. I was in close touch with Harold Samuels, who's the librarian at Yale, and who's the man that originally was very impressed with everything Stanley had done, and called Stan and said what about this, and then what about the photographs, and then finally, what about the records, and of course it's a big archive. And it was really a big step for us too because you know it's hard to make a living in this world, in this music world. And it was a big step, so I think it was important. So I know about the situation about the archives and you're doing just the same thing.

MR: Yes we are.

HD: So I'm very interested.

MR: I think our strength in our archive will be the video interviews. Some other archives have interviews, they're mostly audio. I think it's important to see the person.

HD: I do too. You've got that which Yale doesn't. They don't have that.

MR: And as I said to Stanley, we will be collecting and acquiring other material to accompany the archive.

HD: I had something very interesting that I brought for you to see. Stanley thinks that you will want to see it, so after I'll show it to you.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton I'd like to thank you for your time today, and it's been a pleasure all the way around.

HD: It was a pleasure. It's always a nice world to talk about you know.

MR: All right.

HD: Grand.